tell media leaders that he had tried, and tried hard, but that rebuilding the Congress in UP was a long-term project that would require more than one election to fructify.

A few weeks later, on 7 March, the UP results were out. The SP swept the elections. Akhilesh Yadav, not Rahul Gandhi, was the new great hope of UP. The Congress ended up with twenty-eight seats in the 405-member assembly, just six more than what it had got in the 2007 elections. The Rahul factor, if there ever was one, had failed. If this was a cricket match, the captain would perhaps have been dropped. But this was the Congress party, where the Gandhi family were not just the captains but the coach, manager and chief selectors too. As the enormity of the Congress defeat sunk in, the enduring image for the television cameras was a rather forlorn-looking Rahul Gandhi being consoled by sister Priyanka as the two of them, arms around each other, walked into the forbidding gates of 10, Janpath. If 2012 was the year that Narendra Modi's national ambitions began to crystallize, it was also the moment when Rahul Gandhi was given a rude wake-up call. A durable family name was not enough to overcome serious deficiencies in his political persona.

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A boyish-looking Rahul Gandhi made his political debut in 2004. The decision to formally enter politics, like so much else in the Gandhi family, was taken at the dinner table with Sonia Gandhi and sister Priyanka in attendance. Rahul, we were told, was the apple of his mother's eye—'She just can't say no to him and he can be very obstinate,' is what a family friend told me—and Sonia was keen to see him take over what, for all purposes, had become a family business. Till then, he had zealously guarded his privacy. There was the occasional gossip item of a Latin American girlfriend he had been photographed with but little else. Rahul, we were told, was working with a management consultancy firm in London, was not particularly enamoured of politics and was still debating whether to live abroad or return to take forward the family legacy. He had seen his